

Social Identity Effects in a Belief–Attitude–Intentions Hierarchy: Implications for Corporate Sponsorship

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ABSTRACT

Companies have increasingly turned to sponsorship as a marketing communications vehicle in the hopes that the goodwill that consumers feel toward an event, cause, or sports team will rub off on their brands. The current study tests a beliefs–attitude–intentions hierarchy in the context of the corporate sponsorship of a major university’s sports teams. The direct and indirect effects of social identity with the university’s teams (i.e., team identification) on intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor are also considered. A random-digit dialing methodology was used to collect data from 368 individuals. In general, the results supported the hypotheses. Of special interest was team identification’s ability to moderate the effect of attitude on purchase intentions. As predicted, attitude toward purchasing a sponsor’s products was more highly related to purchase intentions for low identifiers than for high identifiers. Specifically, among those with an unfavorable attitude, high identifiers had significantly more positive intentions to purchase than did low identifiers. For high identifiers, it appears that team identification acts as a heuristic that favorably predisposes them to want to buy products from a sponsor in spite of their evaluation of that action. Marketing implications are discussed. © 2001 John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

The first attribute impacting sponsor loyalty is passion . . . Excitement happens momentarily, but passion means constant involvement and interest . . . Sponsors must find where the emotional linkage is and attach themselves to that. ("Sponsor Loyalty . . . It's Not Just for NASCAR Anymore," 1999)

Many companies have turned to sponsorship as a communication vehicle in response to the increased clutter and cost associated with advertising media, consumers' changing habits relative to traditional media, and a need to target specific geographic and lifestyle segments (Belch & Belch, 1995; Shimp, 1997). Sponsorship differs from traditional advertising in that "both the message and medium are inextricably linked" (Meenaghan, 1996, p. 104). The sponsored event, cause, or sports team (i.e., property or sponsee) draws the audience while concurrently informing the audience of the event's core values. Sponsors hope that the personal meanings of the property's values to the consumer will be transferred to its brands and services. One such personal meaning that sponsors seek to tap is the emotional connection that consumers have with a favorite property.

It is unlikely, however, that emotional connection to a preferred property is the only factor influencing intentions to purchase a sponsor's products. It is also important to consider consumers' beliefs about the benefits of sponsorship and attitude toward supporting corporate sponsors. Perhaps the most widely used conceptualization of choice processes suggests that behaviors are best understood as an ordered delineation of beliefs, attitudes, and behavioral intentions (Fishbein & Ajzen, 1975). This approach suggests that an attitude to engage in some behavior is a function of an individual's beliefs and the perceived importance of those beliefs. Behavioral intentions are influenced by that attitude and behavior, in turn, is predicted by intentions.

Accordingly, the current study tests a hierarchy of effects related to consumers' intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor. Also considered is the consumer's emotional connection to the sponsee, which is conceptualized here in terms of social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Specifically, the influence of consumers' beliefs about sponsorship, the perceived importance of those beliefs, and identification with the sponsee on attitude toward purchasing a corporate sponsor's products is examined. Next, the impact of attitude and each of its aforementioned predictors on intentions to purchase products from a sponsor is tested. Finally, the multiplicative effect of sponsee identification and attitude on purchase intentions is investigated. The article begins with a background discussion of these constructs. Hypotheses to be tested in the research are then offered, followed by the methods, results, and discussion sections.

BACKGROUND

Understanding Sponsorship

Sponsorship has been defined as “an investment, in cash or in kind, in an activity, in return for access to the exploitable commercial potential associated with that activity” (Meenaghan, 1991, p. 36). According to *IEG Sponsorship Report* (“No Bugs Here,” 1999), North American corporations are expected to invest \$7.6 billion in sponsorship in 1999, an increase of over 12% from 1998. Approximately 67% (\$509.2 million) of these expenditures will be on sports sponsorships. These figures represent just the fees paid for sponsorship rights and do not include the additional expenditures for leveraging the association through advertising, tie-in promotions, and client entertainment. According to Meenaghan (1994), companies typically spend an amount equal to or greater than the initial rights fee on promoting the sponsorship.

In addition to generating awareness about the linkage, an important communications objective of sponsorship is image enhancement. Keller (1993) has noted that although brand awareness is related to recognition and recall, brand image refers to the cognitive associations held in consumers’ memories about a brand. Meenaghan (1999) has recently argued that research on corporate sponsorship has overemphasized awareness effects and suggested that future research focus on developing theories about how the linkage between a sponsor and sponsee influences the consumer. Similarly, Cornwell and Maignan (1998) have argued that the most important gap existing in the literature today is the “lack of underlying theories and conceptual foundations on which to base scholarly inquiry” (p. 16). Specifically, a need exists to develop a better understanding of how a consumer’s feelings toward a favorite property influences purchase intentions and behaviors.

Companies investing in sponsorship hope that the favorable associations or personal meanings held by consumers toward a property will rub off (Javalgi, Traylor, Gross, & Lampman, 1994; Stipp & Schiavone, 1996) or be transferred to the brand via the sponsorship association (Gwinner, 1997; McDaniel, 1999; Meenaghan, 1991; Ukman, 1996). Keller (1993) has referred to this transference in terms of secondary associations. An especially important secondary association in the case of sponsorship is the consumer’s emotional connection to the property. Crimmins and Horn (1996) argued that only those consumers who are true fans of a property would reward a sponsor with their patronage. Anecdotal evidence supports this notion. Data collected from a national probability sample of 1000 individuals who described themselves as NASCAR fans indicated that 71% of the respondents said that they “almost always” or “frequently” chose brands of NASCAR sponsors over competitors simply because of the sponsorship. Moreover, 42% said that they switched brands after a manufacturer became a sponsor (“Performance Research Quantifies NASCAR Impact,” 1994).

Social Identity and Sports Teams

For the purposes of this study, a consumer's emotional connection or attachment to a sponsored property is conceptualized in terms of social identity theory. A person's self-concept is comprised of a number of self-identities, each varying along a continuum ranging from personal identity at one end to social identity at the other. Whereas personal identity reflects idiosyncratic differences that are characteristic of a specific individual, social identity derives from category or group membership. A person is likely to behave as a group member in those situations where social categorization is made salient and as an individual when personal identity is salient. Past research in the business literature has investigated social identification with organizations such as companies (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Dutton, Dukerich, & Harquail, 1994; Fisher, Maltz, & Jaworski, 1997), an alma mater (Mael & Ashforth, 1992), and a museum (Bhattacharya, Rao, & Glynn, 1995).

The social identity of interest in this study is an individual's sense of oneness with a sports team. Wann and Branscombe (1993) defined team identification in terms of one's level of attachment to or concern about a particular sports team. In a discussion of the solidarity and self-definition existing among British soccer fans, Hogg and Abrams (1988) noted that "support for the home team is more than an act, it is part of identification with that team and/or what it represents" (p. 128). For those most strongly attached, a sports team represents an especially salient self-identity from which significant ego enhancement is derived (Cialdini et al., 1976). Thus, it is not surprising that those fans who are most highly identified often live vicariously through their team and frequently view its successes and failures as personal successes and failures (Hirt, Zillman, Erickson, & Kennedy, 1992). This suggests that there is some level of psychological risk associated with team identification. For example, Wann and Branscombe (1990) found that although highly identified fans frequently bask in the reflected glory of a favorite team's success, they are unable to psychologically distance themselves after a team's failure.

A central tenet of social identity theory is that group affiliation is motivated by a desire for positive distinctiveness from other social groups and that group members display discrimination and in-group bias to achieve this. For example, compared to those low in team identification, highly identified fans are more likely to derogate fans of an opposing team (Branscombe & Wann, 1994) and show favoritism to others who share their fanaticism toward the team (Wann & Branscombe, 1995). A consequence arising from in-group favoritism is the tendency for highly identified fans to exhibit biased attributional processing favoring their preferred team following a game (Lau & Russell, 1980; Wann & Dolan, 1994). The need for positive distinctiveness also leads

to behavioral consequences. Highly identified fans are more likely to purchase licensed team merchandise (Fisher & Wakefield, 1998; Wann & Branscombe, 1993) and attend games (Fisher & Wakefield, 1998; Schurr, Wittig, Ruble, & Ellen, 1988) than are those with lower levels of team identification.

Beliefs, Belief Importance, and Attitude Strength

Although the preceding explains how team identification contributes to favorable intentions to purchase products from a team sponsor, it does not consider how a consumer's underlying beliefs about the benefits of sponsorship and the perceived importance of those beliefs contribute to an attitude toward supporting corporate sponsors. Eagly and Chaiken (1993) defined an attitude as "a psychological tendency that is expressed by evaluating a particular entity with some degree of favor or disfavor" (p. 1). A psychological tendency refers to a type of bias that predisposes an individual's evaluative responses in either a positive or negative direction. Evaluative responses are specific thoughts about an attitude object. Thoughts in this case may be conceptualized as beliefs, where beliefs may be viewed as the linkages between an attitude object and some attribute, characteristic, outcome, goal, or value (Fishbein & Ajzen, 1975). The attributes linked to an attitude object vary along a positive-negative continuum and the strength of these associations represents the strength of the belief (Jaccard, Radecki, Wilson, & Dittus, 1995). For example, one person may believe that sponsorship reduces a team's operating expenses and will, therefore, lead to lower ticket prices. This belief associates an attitude object (i.e., sponsorship) with a favorable evaluation. Conversely, another person might be more skeptical about sponsorship and believe that companies engage in sponsorship simply as a means for generating more revenue. A third person may be ambivalent toward the attitude object.

Beliefs play a central role in attitude theory because they provide the groundwork upon which attitudes are constructed. When thinking about an attitude object, a person will add new beliefs that tend to be evaluatively consistent with prior beliefs. The greater the similarity between new and old beliefs, the more polarized or extreme an attitude becomes (Judd & Lusk, 1984; Linville and co-workers, 1980, 1982). Thus, beliefs seen as being important and consistent lead to strong attitudes. Attitudes perceived as being important are more likely to be used when processing information, forming intentions, and taking action (Boninger, Krosnick, & Berent, 1995; Fishbein & Ajzen, 1975). It therefore follows that people who hold favorable beliefs about the benefits of corporate sponsorship and view those beliefs as being important will have a more positive attitude toward supporting a sponsor.

Hypotheses

The central feature of a beliefs–attitude–intentions hierarchy is that beliefs represent the basis for an attitude toward engaging in a specific behavior. Moreover, interattitudinal models of cognitive consistency suggest that people's attitudes tend to be linked to one another in molar cognitive structures (Eagly & Chaiken, 1993). Thus, it is not surprising that research has found social identity with a group to be antecedent to attitude importance (Boninger et al., 1995). This view is also consonant with findings by Shavitt and her colleagues (1990, 1992), who have reported that a distinct function of an attitude is to symbolize and express a person's self-image through identification with salient reference groups. In sum, people tend to have favorable attitudes toward issues that are congruent with salient aspects of their own identities deemed to be positive and also support the institutions that embody those identities (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). The notion of evaluative consistency suggests, therefore, that there will be transference of affect such that identification with a sports team will be positively related to attitudes toward a corporate sponsor of that property.

- H1:** Beliefs (and their perceived importance) are positively related to an attitude toward purchasing products from a corporate sponsor.
- H2:** Identification with a sports team is positively related to an attitude toward purchasing products from a corporate sponsor of that team.

Fishbein and Ajzen (1975) have argued that the proximal predictor of an intention to act in some way is an attitude toward that behavior. They also note that any effect of beliefs and the perceived importance of those beliefs on intentions is fully mediated by that attitude.

- H3:** An attitude toward purchasing products from a corporate sponsor is positively related to purchase intentions.
- H4:** After accounting for the mediating effect of attitude on purchase intentions, beliefs (and their perceived importance) will not be related to intentions.

Fishbein and Ajzen (1975) also argued that variables external to the basic beliefs–attitude–intentions hierarchy are thought to influence intentions only indirectly through their moderating effects on attitude. However, other research suggests that strong feelings toward some object may act as a heuristic that has a direct impact on consumer behavior (see Fazio, Powell, & Williams, 1989; Nedungadi, 1990). Moreover, a variety of behaviors and intentions have been positively linked to objects that fulfill an important social identity function (see Abrams, 1990). Thus, it is hypothesized that the effect of social identity on purchase

intentions will only be partially mediated by an attitude toward the behavior.

- H5:** After accounting for the mediating effects of attitude and beliefs (and their importance), team identification will be positively related to intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor of that team.

Terry and Hogg (1996) recently reported that social identity with a group moderates the influence of attitudes on intentions such that attitudes had a greater effect on intentions among individuals with lower levels of identification than for those high in group identification. Consistent with social identity theory's notion of biased information processing, they concluded that a type of depersonalization occurs for high identifiers such that their behavioral intentions are guided more by a group prototype or norm than by personal factors. In contrast, when identification is low, the critical personal determinant of intentions is the favorability of the person's attitude toward the behavior. In effect, the internalization of a group's values, norms, and goals via social identification has heuristic value in that it acts as a type of cognitive shortcut that colors judgment. Highly identified individuals are more likely to act in a manner that is congruent with what is good for the object of identification regardless of their objective attitude toward the behavior. By so doing, membership to the group is reinforced.

- H6:** Identification with a sports team will moderate the effect of an attitude toward purchasing products from a corporate sponsor on purchase intentions such that the attitude will be more predictive of intentions among those with lower levels of team identification than among those high in team identification.

METHOD

General Procedure and Sample Selection

A random-digit dialing procedure was used in order to draw from a representative population of households in central Ohio with current telephone numbers. Of 603 individuals contacted to participate in the study, 504 agreed to do so. Surveys were professionally administered by the Polimetrics Laboratory for Political and Social Research located on the campus of The Ohio State University. All interviewers had prior experience with administering telephone surveys and were exposed to a 2-hr training session related to the current study. In addition, interviewers administered a draft of the instrument in a telephone pretest to 30 individuals from the sample population. Each household in the study sample was called a minimum of six times before elimination,

with the goal of obtaining complete data from 350 individuals. Complete data were collected from 368 individuals.

Description of Measures

The individual items used to measure the constructs of team identification, beliefs about the benefits of sponsorship, the perceived importance of those beliefs, attitude toward buying products from a corporate sponsor, and purchase intentions are shown in the Appendix. The focus of this study was on respondents' identification with the sports teams at The Ohio State University, a major Division 1-A institution. The decision to select sports teams generally rather than a specific team was based on two reasons. First, the intercollegiate athletic program at the university is the largest in the country, offering 34 varsity sports at the time of this study. Therefore, asking about each sport was impractical. By the same token, focusing on just one sport may have led to the exclusion of another that a respondent truly cared about. Second, corporations generally sponsor an entire athletic program rather than just one sport.

In addition to the variables shown in the Appendix, a group of potential covariates was also included in the questionnaire. Two items addressed respondents' behaviors relative to sporting events. The first assessed the number of times per month that the respondent either watched sports on television or read about sports for 5 or more minutes. The second asked about the number of times in the past year that the respondent had paid admission to watch a sporting event. Each item was measured on a 4-point scale (1 = never, 2 = one to three times, 3 = four to nine times, and 4 = ten or more times). A 5-point scale was also included asking about the respondent's overall attitude to the university itself (extremely positive to extremely negative). Finally, demographic information was also collected (sex, age, race, and income).

RESULTS

Description of the Sample

As shown in Table 1, the demographic characteristics of the sample were quite similar to census data for the metropolitan statistical area from which the sample was drawn. Regarding respondents' interest in watching sports, over 88% of the sample indicated that they watched sports on television at least once a month. In addition, approximately 61% of those comprising the sample reported that they had paid admission to one or more sporting events within the past year.

Table 1. Comparison of Metropolitan Statistical Area (MSA) to Study Sample on Selected Demographic Items (percentages).

	MSA	Study Sample
Age		
18–44	62.9	65
45–64	23.7	23
65 or older	10.7	10.6
Income		
Less than \$30,000	33.8	28.3
\$30,001–\$50,000	35.4	31.5
\$50,001–\$75,000	19.6	18.5
\$75,001 or more	10.4	12.2
Race		
African-American	12	8.5
Caucasian	84.7	86
Sex		
Female	52	46
Male	48	54

Determinants of Attitude toward Supporting Corporate Sponsors

Fishbein and Ajzen (1975) suggest that an attitude to engage in some behavior is directly predicted by a composite variable that incorporates beliefs and their evaluative elements. In the current context, attitude is thought to be a function of the extent to which a belief about corporate sponsorship is held (its strength) and the importance of that belief to the individual. Operationally, multiplying each individual belief by its perceived importance and then summing across products in this case creates a composite variable. Both Evans (1991) and Ajzen (1991) outline procedures for testing the predictive contributions of summed products to a dependent variable after accounting for the unique contributions of their constituent parts. They argue that the unique variance attributable to the summed multiplicative terms should be significantly greater than the variance explained by the additive effects.

Accordingly, a hierarchical regression was conducted to examine the independent contribution of the set of multiplicative terms above and beyond the contribution made by the individual items. All items were mean centered prior to the analysis in order to reduce the effects of multicollinearity. The dependent variable, attitude toward supporting corporate sponsors, was first regressed against the three beliefs (see Appendix). The next entry into the model was the perceived importance of each belief. The final entry was the multiplicative terms combining each belief with its perceived importance. The results indicated that the set of three composite terms did not significantly improve the fit of the model, $\Delta R^2 = 0.01$, $F_{\text{cha}}(3,358) = 1.28$, $p > .20$. Further, Cronbach alphas

for the three belief items and the three importance items were, respectively, 0.65 and 0.58. Given the lack of a unique contribution of the interactive terms and low composite reliabilities, the individual belief items and the importance of each were entered individually as predictors in subsequent models.

In order to test the first two hypotheses, a hierarchical regression was conducted in which attitude toward supporting corporate sponsors was again the dependent variable. As before, all items were mean centered prior to the analysis. Initial analyses revealed that control of the effects due to covariates did not change the results. Consequently, covariates were not included in the model. The first entry into the model was the three belief items. Next, the three importance evaluations were entered. The final entry into the model was team identification. This order of entry allowed the examination of whether team identification influenced attitude, after controlling for the effects of beliefs and their perceived importance. Table 2 summarizes the results. Overall, the independent variables accounted for 34% of the variance in attitude toward purchasing products from corporate sponsors. Partial support is also found for the first hypothesis in that two of the three belief items were significantly related to attitude. Specifically, individuals who believed that sponsorship led to reduced admission costs to sporting events had a more favorable attitude. Also, those who thought that corporate sponsorship improved the image of a company had a more positive attitude. Only one importance item was related to attitude. People who thought that a good corporate image was important had a more favorable attitude. Consistent with the second hypothesis, higher levels of team iden-

Table 2. Regression of Attitude on Beliefs, Belief Importance, and Team Identification.

Step	Predictor	<i>R</i>	<i>R</i> ² _{adj}	ΔR^2	<i>F</i> _{cha}	<i>df</i>	β
1		0.41	0.16	—	24.78**	3, 364	
	REDTIC						0.17*
	MAKEPOSS						0.02
	IMAGE						0.13*
2		0.51	0.26	0.09	14.79**	3, 361	
	REDTIC IMP						–0.05
	MAKEPOSS						0.06
	IMP						
	IMAGE IMP						0.25**
3		0.60	0.36	0.10	52.78**	1, 360	
	TEAM ID						0.32**

Notes: BELIEFS = REDTIC (sponsorship lowers ticket prices for attendees), MAKEPOSS (sponsorship makes some events possible that would not otherwise take place), IMAGE (sponsorship improves a company's image); BELIEF IMPORTANCE = the perceived importance (IMP) of each belief; TEAM ID = team identification. Beta coefficients estimated after all variables entered in the equation. *R*²_{adj} at the end of Step 3 indicates that 36% of the variance in attitude was explained by the predictors.

* < 0.01.

** < 0.001.

tification were positively related to attitude toward supporting corporate sponsors, $\Delta R^2 = 0.10$, $F_{\text{cha}}(1,360) = 52.78$, $p < .001$.

Predicting Intentions to Purchase Products from Corporate Sponsors

Next, a moderated regression analysis for behavioral intentions was conducted. The first entry into the model was attitude toward the behavior. Next, the three belief items and the importance of each were entered as a block. The third entry was team identification. The final entry was the interaction term of team identification and attitude. This model explicitly considers whether the effects of beliefs and their importance on purchase intentions are mediated by attitude. In addition, the model tests whether the direct effect of team identification on purchase intentions is mediated by the more proximal determinants of intentions predicted by Fishbein and Ajzen (1975). Consistent with the prior analyses, all items were first mean centered and no differences were found after controlling for covariates. It should also be noted that the bivariate correlations for all of the variables included in the final model ranged from 0.15 to 0.56 (attitude and purchase intentions) with a mean of 0.29.

Table 3 summarizes the results of the analysis. Consistent with H3,

Table 3. Regression of Purchase Intentions on Beliefs, Belief Importance, Attitude, and Team Identification.

Step	Predictor	<i>R</i>	<i>R</i> ² _{adj}	ΔR^2	<i>F</i> _{cha}	<i>df</i>	β
1	ATT	0.56	0.31	—	166.79**	1, 366	0.39**
2	REDTIC	0.60	0.35	0.04	4.04*	6, 360	0.03
	MAKEPOSS						0.06
	IMAGE						−0.02
	REDTIC IMP						−0.04
	MAKEPOSS IMP						0.11*
	IMAGE IMP						0.10*
3	TEAM ID	0.63	0.40	0.05	26.68**	1, 359	0.23**
4	ID × ATT	0.65	0.42	0.02	11.25**		−0.14**

Notes: BELIEFS = REDTIC (sponsorship lowers ticket prices for attendees), MAKEPOSS (sponsorship makes some events possible that would not otherwise take place), IMAGE (sponsorship improves a company's image); BELIEF IMPORTANCE = the perceived importance (IMP) of each belief; TEAM ID = team identification; ATT = attitude; ID × ATT = interaction term. Beta coefficients estimated after all variables entered in the equation. *R*²_{adj} at the end of Step 4 indicates that 42% of the variance in purchase intentions was explained by the predictors.

* < 0.05.

** < 0.001.

attitude toward the behavior accounted for 31% of the variance in purchase intentions, $F_{\text{cha}}(1,366) = 166.79, p < .001$. In contrast to H4, the influence of beliefs and their perceived importance were only partially mediated by attitude, $\Delta R^2 = 0.04, F_{\text{cha}}(6,360) = 4.04, p < .05$. However, the effect of beliefs on purchase intentions was much less than that of attitude. As hypothesized, the influence of team identification on intentions after accounting for the mediating effects of attitude and beliefs was also highly significant, $\Delta R^2 = 0.05, F_{\text{cha}}(1,359) = 26.68, p < .001$. However, each of these main effects was tempered by the hypothesized two-way interaction, indicating that attitude was more predictive of purchase intentions among those with lower levels of team identification, $\Delta R^2 = 0.02, F_{\text{cha}}(1,358) = 11.25, p < .001$.

Figure 1 graphically displays the two-way interaction of team identification and attitude with the use of a procedure described by Aiken and West (1991). The upper line is the slope at one standard deviation

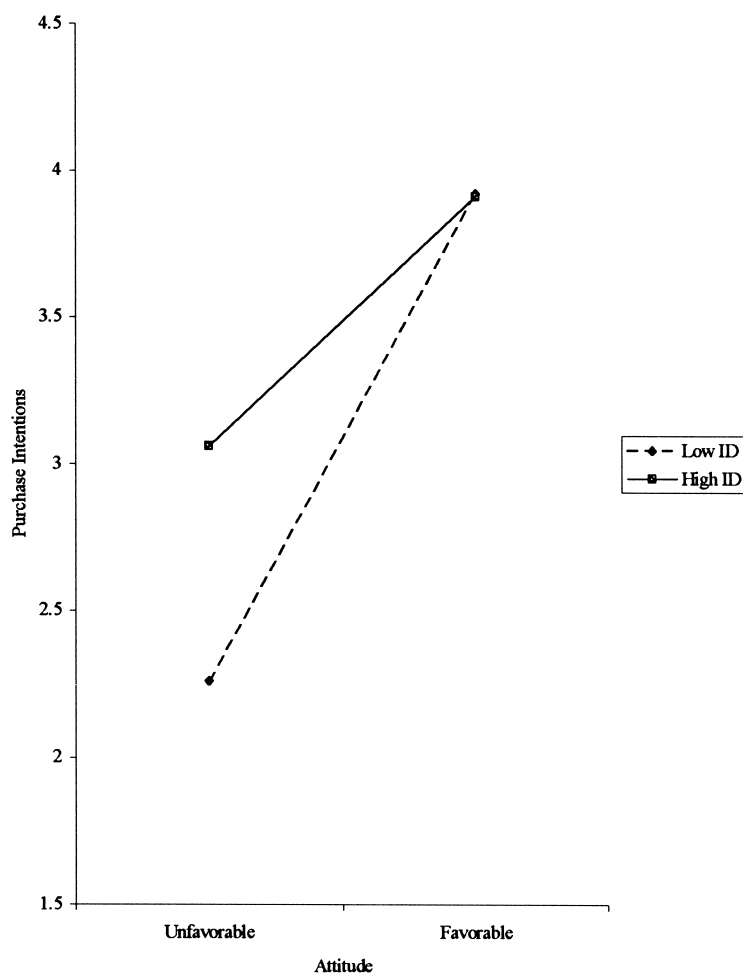


Figure 1. Attitude by team identification interaction on purchase intentions.

above the mean of team identification and the lower line is the slope at one standard deviation below the mean. As shown in Figure 1, the nature of the interaction was disordinal and indicates that the difference in purchase intentions as a function of attitude was greater for those low in team identification than for those who were highly identified ($t_s = 9.39, 5.50, p_s < .001$). If one refers to the right side of the graph, it can be seen that no differences in purchase intentions due to identification were found among those with favorable attitudes toward supporting corporate sponsors, $t = 1.51, p > .10$. In contrast, among those with an unfavorable attitude, the purchase intentions of highly identified individuals were significantly greater than for those with lower levels of identification, $t = 6.58, p < .001$.

DISCUSSION

In general, the beliefs–attitude–intentions hierarchy tested in this research is supported. It appears that people's intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor are predicted by an attitude toward that behavior, which is, in turn, influenced by beliefs about the consequences of that behavior. In this study, the importance of those beliefs appeared to have little influence on attitude. In addition, although posited in the past (Crimmins & Horn, 1996), the results empirically demonstrate the importance of considering the effects of team identification in a sports sponsorship context.

Meenaghan (1999) referred to the "Holy Grail" of future research on sponsorship as being tied to a better understanding of how a consumer is affected by a company's association with a property. The current study considered this in somewhat different terms. Specifically, the focus here was on how the strength and favorability of the association existing between a consumer and the property influenced intentions toward buying a sponsor's products. Consistent with past work on social identity's effects on political attitudes (cf. Boninger et al., 1995), it appears that when team identification is high, people are more likely to have a positive attitude toward supporting corporate sponsors. The results also show that team identification's effect on purchase intentions is not wholly mediated by an attitude toward that behavior. In effect, it appears that connection to a team has a positive direct effect on intentions toward buying a team sponsor's product irrespective of the specific attitude toward that behavior.

Clearly, however, the most important contribution of this study is the finding that team identification moderates the effect of attitude on intentions to purchase. Attitude had a greater influence on purchase intentions for those low in identification than for those more highly identified with the team. This effect is consistent with the results reported by Terry and Hogg (1996), that focused on personal health habits.

Highly identified individuals appear more likely to form behavioral intentions that are congruent with the goals and objectives of the group (i.e., the team in this study) than they are with personal factors such as an attitude toward the behavior. In contrast to those with lower levels of team identification, high identifiers are more likely to base their behavioral intentions on what is perceived as being good for the group rather than on a personal assessment of the behavior itself.

The results of this study suggest, therefore, that the presence of a linkage between a sponsor and property may function as a heuristic (Chaiken, Liberman, & Eagly, 1989) or peripheral cue (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986; cf. Gwinner, 1997) for high identifiers in that it triggers behavioral intentions that are independent of an objective evaluation of that behavior. Terry and Hogg (1996) referred to this in terms of the depersonalization of group membership. Depersonalization is a process of "self-stereotyping" whereby individuals see themselves as being more of the group than as unique personalities as defined in terms of their individual differences from others (Turner et al., 1987, p. 50). The depersonalization of self-perception is likely to occur only when the individual has internalized the values, norms, and goals of the group (cf. Kelman, 1961). Team identification determines the course of action for those who are most highly affiliated because such behavior reinforces or strengthens their identity as members of the team.

IMPLICATIONS

Many marketers believe that sponsorship cuts through the clutter of traditional media. In contrast to the more intrusive nature of traditional marketing communications, sponsorship represents an indirect form of persuasion that can improve the perceptions of a brand by linking it to a property with which the target audience is already highly identified (Crimmins & Horn, 1996). Although the focus of this study was on identification with a sports team, the findings also have broader implications. Properties ranging from air shows to zoos must rely on corporate support in the form of sponsorship. It is likely that the effects found here also apply in other contexts involving important social identities (e.g., religious groups, university alumni, and minority groups). The findings reported in this study give rise to the following implications.

First, and perhaps most obvious, great care should be taken prior to investing in sponsorship to determine whether the property's core audience matches the company's customer base (cf. Varadarajan & Menon, 1988). In particular, companies should consider the level of commitment existing in its target market for the property. Sponsorship decisions are often made on the basis of the exposure a company expects to receive from the alignment. Although critical for a sponsorship's success, basing a sponsorship decision on mere exposure is a bit like putting the cart

before the horse. Companies that align themselves with properties for which their consumers have no real passion have little to leverage. As noted by Crimmins and Horn (1996), "(F)ans are grateful for sponsorship. Others are not" (p. 17). It follows then that the level of gratitude necessary to elicit a desire to repay a sponsor's investment with a product purchase is likely to occur only for those individuals most highly identified with the property.

The results reported here also indicate that favorable beliefs about the benefits derived by a property from corporate sponsorship are positively related to an attitude toward buying products from a sponsor. Moreover, beliefs were found to have an unmediated direct effect on purchase intentions. An implication of these findings is that sponsors have an opportunity to influence consumers' beliefs by educating them as to how the association between a brand and property should be interpreted (Crimmins & Horn, 1996). In general, greater correspondence is likely to occur between an attitude and behavior when the number of beliefs supporting that attitude increases (Jaccard et al., 1995). Thus, communications designed to increase the number and strength of beliefs held by a consumer about sponsorship will ultimately lead to stronger attitudes. This implies that rather than simply tagging the end of an advertisement with the property's logo, an investment in sponsorship requires the association be integrated in some meaningful way into the company's overall communications plan. This approach allows the sponsor to create more favorable attitudes by providing consumers with a set of varied messages, each focusing on different underlying beliefs about how the sponsorship should be interpreted (cf. Haugtvedt, Schumann, Schneier, & Warren, 1994).

Finally, regarding the subdiscipline of sports marketing, the findings emphasize the importance of fans' identification with a team to corporate sponsors. However, recent trends such as increased ticket costs, player misconduct, team relocation, and player strikes may contribute to lessening fans' avidity toward a team. In such cases, it is unlikely that fans will feel a sense of reciprocity toward a team sponsor. Thus, it becomes of paramount importance for sports marketers to strengthen fans' identification with the team. This might take the form of player appearances, youth training camps, or monthly newsletters to interested fans. Another tactic may be for sports teams to align themselves with other civic events or social causes to enhance their prestige locally. For example, the Oakland Athletics baseball team has recently become a sponsor of a local amphitheater in an effort to create a more positive image as a member of the community.

Limitations and Future Research

As with any study, a number of limitations must be acknowledged. First, this research considered just intentions as an endpoint, not actual be-

havior. Future research should investigate how intentions influence actual behavior in the sequence described here. Also, purchase intentions were not related to an actual sponsor (e.g., retailer, brand, etc.). Rather, only a broader intention to purchase from a company that sponsors the university's sports teams was considered. In spite of Keller's (1993) warning that the inclusion of real brand names may confound results, the consideration of actual companies and brand names would be an interesting extension of this research. Also recognized as a limitation here is that the items used to assess beliefs were not elicited by an independent sample (Ajzen & Fishbein, 1980). Rather, these items were drawn from past research on sponsorship beliefs conducted by marketing practitioners. It may be that an elicitation study would have yielded a different set of beliefs than those used here. However, the use of questions commonly included by marketers to assess beliefs about sponsorship does at least represent an element of external validity that has some merit.

CONCLUSION

Corporate partnerships with a variety of different types of properties are becoming an increasingly common form of marketing communication. In an effort to influence brand attitudes and purchase intentions, companies engage in sponsorship hoping that the passion that their consumers feel for a favorite property will "rub off" on their products. The results of this study lend credence to this proposition. By supporting properties that members of their target market care deeply about, corporate sponsors have a unique opportunity not only to "connect" with consumers, but to also differentiate themselves from competitors.

APPENDIX

The following items dealt with team identification.¹ Items were measured with the use of a 5-point scale. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.86$.

How important is it to you that the Ohio State University athletic teams win (not very important/very important)?

How strongly do you see yourself as a fan of Ohio State athletic teams (not a fan/very strong fan)?

How often do you display the Ohio State name or insignia at your workplace, where you live, or on your clothing (never/always)?

¹ Items included here were modified from Wann and Branscombe's (1993) Sports Spectator Identification Scale.

How important is being a fan of Ohio State athletics to you (not very important/very important)?

How strongly do your friends see you as a fan of Ohio State athletic teams (not a fan/very strong fan)?

The following items measured beliefs.² Items were measured with the use of a 7-point strongly disagree to strongly agree scale. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.65$.

Corporate sponsorship of Ohio State athletic teams results in:

- Making some events possible that would not otherwise take place (MAKEPOSS).
- Lowering ticket prices for those attending a sporting event (RED-TIC).
- An improved image for the company (IMAGE).

The following items measured perceived importance of beliefs. Items were measured with the use of a 7-point very unimportant to very important scale. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.58$.

Sponsoring athletic events that would not otherwise take place is:

Reducing ticket prices at sporting events is:

Supporting companies with a good corporate image is:

These items were used to measure attitude toward buying products from sponsors. Items were measured with the use of 5-point scales. Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.76$.

Do you think that trying to buy products from a company that sponsors The Ohio State University's athletic teams is: (very bad/very good)?

How favorable are you towards trying to buy products from a company that sponsors the athletic teams at The Ohio State University: (extremely unfavorable/extremely favorable)?

Overall is your attitude about trying to buy products from a company that sponsors The Ohio State University's athletic teams: (very positive/very negative; reverse coded)?

² Items used to measure beliefs and their perceived importance were drawn from two different studies. The first was conducted for John Hancock Financial Services by the advertising agency Hill, Holliday, Connors, Cosmopoulos, Inc. ("Measuring Sponsorship's Impact on Corporate Image: Findings from John Hancock," 1993); and the other for the American Coalition for Entertainment and Sports Sponsorship by the Roper Organization Inc. ("Public Attitudes Toward Sponsors of Pro Sports Events: A Roper Poll," 1993).

Items measuring intention to buy products from sponsors follow. Each was measured on a 5-point scale. Pearson correlation: 0.46, $p < .001$.

How likely is it that you will try to buy at least one product made by a company that sponsors the athletic teams at Ohio State in the next three months (very likely/very unlikely, reverse coded)?

Whenever possible, I try to buy products made by companies that sponsor the athletic teams at The Ohio State University (strongly disagree/strongly agree)?

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